

ENGLISH LANGUAGE PAPER 4

PART A Group Interaction

Below is an extract from a column about robots in the service industry:

Meals on Wheels

Friendly and attentive waiters are a key ingredient in the running of a successful restaurant. Now more and more robots are replacing humans by providing a reliable waitressing service in Chinese restaurants and hotels.

One such new restaurant in Jiangsu Province, China, is staffed by 15 robots that not only carry food to a diner's table, but help cook it too. The robots greet customers, deliver food and help with cooking in the kitchen and if they encounter a rude customer, there is no chance of them spitting in the food. Some of the robots can manage polite conversation, as well as greeting customers with 40 different phrases. Just like with humans, the energy-intensive job takes its toll on the robots, which are expected to offer between five and eight years' service. Each one costs around HK\$50,000.

Another robot restaurant serving dumplings and noodles cooked by robots was recently set up in Harbin, Heilongjiang Province. When a diner walks into this restaurant, an usher robot says, 'Earth person hello. Welcome to the Robot Restaurant.' There is even a singing robot to serenade diners.

Similar robots are also taking over small tasks in hotels. The Pengheng Space Capsules Hotel in Shenzhen has robotic receptionists and doormen as well as mechanical waiters. Because the robots are not paid a salary, a stay at the hotel is cheap at just HK\$70 per night.

Your group is planning to write an article for your school magazine about the benefits and problems of introducing robots into the service industry. You may want to talk about:

- advantages of using robots
- reasons why people might be against using robots
- other industries that could benefit from using robots
- anything else you think is important

PART B Individual Response

1. Would you like to work with robots?
2. Would you like to eat in a restaurant served by robots?
3. Do you think robots can replace teachers?
4. Do you think robots will replace people in most jobs?
5. Do you think robots could do any useful work in your secondary school?
6. In a restaurant, would you rather be served by a robot or a real person?
7. If you had a robot, what would you like it to do?
8. Do you think it is worth spending fifty-thousand dollars on a restaurant robot?